Let AI Interview You First

Open r.isba.co/ask-first

Open your usual AI.

Pick one unfinished idea.

Teaching, research, or service.

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shondaland

“A conversation, not a form.”

Before I designed anything.

Find your idea's unknowns

1. Three questions.
2. Blind spot pass.
3. A spec.
4. A visual.

First, I'll ask you

Which AI, for work?

Workdays using AI?

Has AI interviewed you?

Prompt AI your usual way

Use your usual settings.

Keep this tab open.

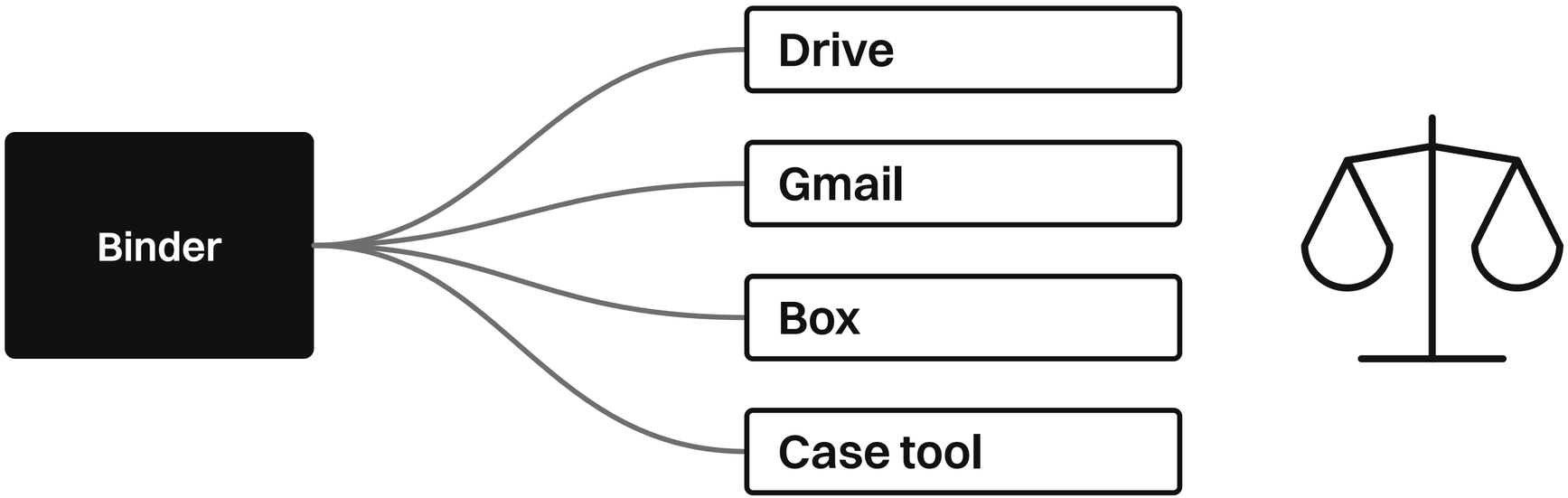
Look at the answer

Was it polished?

Could you defend it?

Did AI ask before answering?

“We need hearing binders prepped by 3 p.m.”



The problem: four systems.

A request is a clue

A STAKEHOLDER SAYS

“We need a dashboard.”

YOU TYPED

Your first prompt.

Stakeholders arrive with a solution

So do we.

Finding your unknowns

	I KNOW IT	I DON'T KNOW IT
I'M AWARE	KNOWN KNOWNS **What I already tell AI** Your prompt	KNOWN UNKNOWNS **What I haven't figured out** Three questions
I'M NOT AWARE	UNKNOWN KNOWNS **What I'd know on sight** Spec and visual	UNKNOWN UNKNOWNS **What I haven't considered** Blind spot pass

Thariq Shihipar, 2026

Match model to unknowns

NOW: MANY UNKNOWNS

Strongest model, effort up

LATER: A CLEAR SPEC

Smaller model, less effort

Your turn

1. Open r.isba.co/ask-first
2. New tab, new chat.
3. Pick your strongest model.
4. Paste prompt 1.
5. Add your idea.

Answer out loud

Talk, or type.

Pick one, then say why.

None fits? Say your own.

Or mix and match.

1 Three questions

What I haven’t figured out.

AI asks before answering.

Send prompt 1.

2 Blind spot pass

What I haven’t considered.

Now AI knows your situation.

Paste prompt 2.

3 The spec

What I’d know on sight.

Your thinking, on record.

Fix what AI guessed.

Paste prompt 3.

4 The visual

What I'd know on sight.

Easier to scan than read.

React to what you see.

Ask for two variants.



Final Project Peer Review: Design Proposal

One-Page Specification

DRAFT For Your Review

Purpose: Teach students to evaluate research design — not just polish their own work.

1. Goal
Build methodological judgment.

Students will be able to:

1. Identify key strengths and weaknesses in a research design.
2. Judge alignment (question, variables, sampling, measures, analysis).
3. Distinguish real flaws from reasonable trade-offs.
4. Support an overall judgment with methodological reasoning.
5. Communicate constructive criticism in a short reviewer memo.

Primary outcome: students learn to evaluate designs. Secondary benefit: stronger final projects.

2. Key Constraints
What we have to work within.

- **Timing:** Review occurs at the design-proposal stage (before data collection).
- **Novice reviewers:** Little or no prior experience evaluating others' work.
- **Two-part review:** Guided diagnostic form → short reviewer memo.
- **Focus:** Research design issues (not grammar or style).
- **Quality control:** Minimize confident but incorrect advice.
- **Fairness:** Pairing must account for topic/method differences and interpersonal dynamics.
- **Schedule:** Early enough for authors to use feedback before data collection.

Key Assumptions (Guesses)

- [GUESS] Fits within one class session + limited outside work.
- [GUESS] Same course (not another section/semester).
- [GUESS] Modest grade weight for reviewer, authors not graded on accepting feedback.
- [GUESS] Proposals may use different methods (review form will include universal + method-specific criteria).
- [GUESS] Reviews are identifiable (not anonymous) unless needed.
- **Confirmed:** Each student reviews two proposals.
- [GUESS] Each student also receives feedback from two peers.

3. Review Focus
What students should evaluate.

- Fit between research question and design
- Construct definition and operationalization
- Sampling logic and potential sources of bias
- Reliability and validity of measures
- Feasibility and ethical considerations
- Fit between evidence and claims
- Appropriateness of planned analysis

4. Review Process (High Level)

1. **Submit Proposal** — Students share design proposal.
2. **Complete Guided Form** — Review two peers using structured questions.
3. **Write Reviewer Memo** — Short memo in your own words (per review).
4. **Receive Feedback** — Get feedback from two peers.
5. **Revise Design** — Consider and respond to feedback (before data collection).

5. What Good Looks Like
A strong review will:

1. Diagnose a consequential design issue.
2. Explain why it matters (using course concepts).
3. Prioritize major vs. minor issues.
4. Recognize defensible trade-offs.
5. Suggest a realistic revision or ask a helpful question.
6. Provide a concise overall assessment.

6. Evidence of Success
How we'll know it's working.

- Comments focus on design (not writing or topic preference).
- Reviewer memos make a clear, evidence-based judgment.
- Authors can explain which feedback they accepted, modified, or rejected — and why.
- Few instances of clearly incorrect advice going uncorrected (instructor spot-checks).
- Stronger methodological judgment in a later assignment, exam, or final reflection.
- Target (initial): ≥ 80% of reviews identify one consequential design issue and justify it accurately.

7. Next Step
Draft the assessment criteria for the reviewer's work, including what distinguishes an accurate methodological judgment from a plausible-sounding but weak one.

What would you update, correct, or remove?

Peer Review Spec | Final Project | Research Methods (Upper Division)

Your Input Will Shape the Design

Copilot's visual, test run

Paste prompt 4.

Before and after

Your first answer.

Your spec and visual.

What’s different?

You were the stakeholder

MY CAPSTONE STUDENTS

Interview the client.

Write the brief.

Sketch a mockup.

TODAY, THE AI

Interviewed you.

Wrote the spec.

Drew the visual.

Students finished the assignment, but do they understand what they built?

Interviews showed who understood.

A spec before the draft.

Match model to the work

DESIGNING SOMETHING NEW

Strongest model, effort up

Prompts: r.isba.co/ask-first

DOING IT FROM THE SPEC

Smaller model, less effort

Make it reusable

A skill: saved instructions.

“Turn this into reusable instructions.”

Mine: interview-me.

r.isba.co/ask-first

“You can outsource your thinking, but you can’t outsource your understanding.”

Andrej Karpathy (co-founder of OpenAI, former head of AI at Tesla), quoting a line he keeps returning to · AI Ascent, 2026 · play 27:42 to 29:33

Let AI interview you first

Keep going on today’s idea.

Or try a new one.

Fix what AI guessed.

r.isba.co/ask-first · gregory.lontok@lmu.edu

interview-me, as a skill

Find it at r.isba.co/ask-first

Download the zip.

Claude, ChatGPT: upload it.

Gemini, Copilot: paste it.

Say: interview me first.

Sources

Shihipar, T. (2026). Finding your unknowns.

Larkin and Simon (1987). Why a diagram is (sometimes) worth ten thousand words.

Karpathy, A. (2026). AI Ascent, with Stephanie Zhan.

Impeccable, a design skill for AI agents. impeccable.style